A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

Introduction and Preparation for Shabbat: Friday Afternoon & Candles

Class 1 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 1 of 14

Topic: Introduction and Preparation for Shabbat — Friday Afternoon & Candle Lighting

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 16 October 2018

Halachic basis: Primarily the rulings of Chacham Ovadia Yosef zt"l, noting Ashkenazi practice and the Ben Ish Chai / Kabbalistic view where they differ.

Opening

The evening opened with words of welcome from Barbara, chair of the shul team, who noted that in the shul's roughly fifteen-year history there had never been a series of fourteen shiurim on one topic. The shiurim were to be recorded so that anyone missing a session could catch up.

The Rabbi thanked the rabbis of the synagogue, Dr. Kahen — described as a driving force behind the initiative — the Tiferet Eyal committee, and everyone attending. Coming out every week to learn Hilchot Shabbat is, he said, itself praiseworthy — *Chazak u'Baruch*.

Part A — Why Shabbat Is So Central

"Shomer Shabbat" — why this mitzvah defines us

We ask whether someone is **Shomer Shabbat** — we do not ask the same about any of the other mitzvot. Shabbat is the one observance by which a person's religious commitment is commonly measured. Why?

Zachor and Shamor

The Torah records the Ten Commandments twice — in Parashat Yitro (Shemot) and Parashat Va'etchanan (Devarim). The two versions are almost identical, but Chazal immediately noted one major difference:

זָכוֹר אֶת יוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת לְקַדְּשׁוֹ — (Shemot 20:8) *Remember the Shabbat day to sanctify it.*

שָׁמוֹר אֶת יוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת לְקַדְּשׁוֹ — (Devarim 5:12) *Guard the Shabbat day to sanctify it.*

Chazal teach: **זכור ושמור בדבור אחד נאמרו** — *Zachor and Shamor were said in a single utterance.* Something beyond human comprehension — but its message is that the two are **equally important**:

	Zachor — remembering	Shamor — guarding
Character	The positive dimension	The restraining dimension
Expressions	Honouring Shabbat, good food, fine clothes, shul, time with family, appreciating Hashem and Torah	Refraining from melacha — the precise details of what one may not do

Many Jews are **Zochrei Shabbat** — they make Kiddush, have the meals, come to shul — without being **Shomrei Shabbat**. A Shomer Shabbat both marks the day positively *and* keeps its details. Neither half is enough alone: one cannot only enjoy the day without its laws, nor only keep the laws without appreciating the beauty of the day.

The painting analogy. Standing before a beautiful painting, if you come too close and fixate on each brushstroke, you lose the beauty of the whole. Yet without every brushstroke there is no painting. **Zachor** is the transcendent beauty of the whole; **Shamor** is the detail. We need both.

The email analogy. One wrong dot or hyphen in an email address and the message goes to Australia. The detail matters — but it serves the whole.

Three reasons Shabbat is so fundamental

1. **Creation** — Hashem created the world in six days and rested on the seventh. By working six days and resting on the seventh, we affirm that the universe has a Creator. (Stated explicitly in the Torah.)
2. **Yetziat Mitzrayim** — Every Kiddush mentions **זֵכֶר לִיצִיאַת מִצְרָיִם**. In Egypt, despite the back-breaking labour, Pharaoh allowed a rest on the seventh day (as cited from the Moreh Nebuchim). Remembering Egypt affirms not just a Creator, but a God **actively involved in the world** — Divine Providence, as the miracles of the Exodus demonstrated.
3. **Being, not doing** — Wherever the Torah commands Shabbat it prefaces: **שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים תַּעֲבֹד** — *six days shall you work.* The contrast is deliberate: six days of *doing*, a seventh day of simply *being*. "We are human beings, not human doings." The first question people ask is "What do you do?" — Shabbat reminds us that our identity is not our occupation.

The Rosh Hashanah analogy — Malchiyot, Zichronot, Shofarot

The Rabbi recalled his Rosh Hashanah drasha on the three sections of Musaf, using the image of driving a car:

- **Malchiyot** — the clear **windscreen**: our vision ahead.
- **Zichronot** — the **mirrors**: the vision must rest on our past, our *mesorah*.
- **Shofarot** — the **horn, traffic lights and "tiredness kills, take a break" signs**: stopping to reassess whether we are on track.

Yom Kippur was a month ago — what remains of it? **Shabbat is a weekly "mini Yom Kippur"**: a regular stop for reflection on the past week and building toward the next. And Shabbat lets us live in the present — not anxious about the week behind or the week ahead.

Shabbat as the centre of the week (Maharal)

We usually see Shabbat as the *end* of the week. The Kabbalists and the **Maharal of Prague** (16th century) see it as the **centre**. A three-dimensional object has six sides, but those six planks are meaningless until there is a centre around which they are built — an invisible centre that gives the structure its meaning. So too the six weekdays revolve around Shabbat: from Tuesday night we prepare toward Shabbat; from Sunday we descend from it. **Shabbat gives meaning to the whole week.**

Why learn Shabbat in such detail — the three mitzvot of Marah

Before Matan Torah, at **Marah**, Hashem gave Israel a few mitzvot to prepare them, including **Parah Adumah**, **Dinim** (civil law) and **Shabbat** (Sanhedrin 56b). The Maharal explains these represent three dimensions of Torah learning:

Mitzvah	Dimension
Parah Adumah	Philosophical depth — a mitzvah even Shlomo HaMelech could not fathom
Dinim	Analytical rigour — dissecting and adjudicating
Shabbat	**Breadth** — so many details that one must keep learning and learning

Fourteen shiurim will not make anyone a master of Hilchot Shabbat — it is a lifetime's study. The goal is to give **musagim** (concepts): to know *where there is an issue*, so that one knows to ask.

Rabbi Yonatan Eybeschutz (approx. 300 years ago): it is almost impossible to be Shomer Shabbat without regularly learning Hilchot Shabbat.

Approach of the course: Rulings will follow mainly **Chacham Ovadia Yosef** zt"l (whose yahrzeit had just passed), noting **Ashkenazi** practice and, for those who follow it, the **Ben Ish Chai** / Kabbalistic view where it differs.

Part B — Friday Afternoon

1. Working on Friday afternoon

The halacha: The Shulchan Aruch (OC 251) rules that from **Mincha Ketana** — roughly **2½ hours before sunset** — one should stop working. One who continues **אינו רואה סימן ברכה** — *sees no sign of blessing* from that work. Chazal wanted us to *prepare* for Shabbat, not jump straight into it.

Taken literally, that would mean leaving the office 3½ hours before Shabbat. In practice, **four reasons** make this halacha rarely applicable:

1. **Only arduous, recognisable melacha** was included — plumbing, weaving, writing, field work. **Buying and selling** (*perakmatya*) is permitted until close to Shabbat — hence shops may stay open (though not so late that Jewish staff or customers end up travelling into Shabbat; 20–30 minutes before is generally fine).
2. **Only one's own work** — an **employee** may keep working until close to Shabbat.

3. **Work for Shabbat itself** is permitted — an electrician fixing something for Shabbat, dry-cleaning a garment or a haircut for Shabbat.
4. **Financial loss** — if the work cannot wait (a client would be lost), it is permitted.

Where it does apply: a self-employed **sofer** writing a Sefer Torah due in six months — real melacha, self-employed, not for Shabbat, no loss. Such a person should stop about 2½ hours before Shabbat each Friday.

In all cases: don't just "land" into Shabbat — arrive with preparation and the right frame of mind.

2. Travelling on Friday

The halacha (OC 249): based on the Gemara, one should not set out on a journey of more than roughly **three parsaot** (about 3½ hours) on Erev Shabbat.

The reason is commonly misunderstood. The concern is not getting stranded — it is **food**: arriving somewhere just before Shabbat with nothing prepared, and so failing to enjoy Shabbat properly.

- If the destination **knows you are coming** and will provide food, you may travel up until Shabbat — e.g. a businessman flying home whose wife expects him.
- Where it could still apply: yeshiva students in Israel who would board a bus and arrive unannounced somewhere (say Jerusalem to Tzfat), relying on finding hospitality.
- The **Magen Avraham** (some 400 years ago) already writes that people no longer hesitate over this, since hosts always cook extra.

Caution: never cut it so fine that you are tempted to drive "another ten minutes" into Shabbat. If caught, one would have to stop on the hard shoulder for 25 hours. Leave ample time.

Question from the floor: a participant asked about relying on facilities at the destination (e.g. a place next door being open for food). The Rabbi confirmed: the same principle — provided food will be available, travel is fine.

3. A large meal on Friday

The halacha (OC 249): Chazal forbade sitting down to a **meal one is not accustomed to during the week** — the **entire** Friday — to preserve one's appetite and keep Shabbat distinct.

- Applies only to a meal **with bread (washing)**. Fine food without a bread meal is permitted the whole day.
- For someone who eats out regularly during the week, a restaurant meal is not special — permitted.
- **A seudat mitzvah** — e.g. a **brit milah** — is permitted the whole day, even if lavish.
- From about **three hours before sunset**, especially in winter, one should avoid eating so much that the Shabbat meal is spoiled. (The Rabbi added his own concern — not upsetting a spouse who has worked hard on the Shabbat food!)

Part C — Lighting Shabbat Candles (Hadlakat Nerot)

Status and reward

Some hold lighting candles is rooted in the Torah or the Nevi'im; at the very least it is a rabbinic mitzvah expressing honour for Shabbat. The Gemara (Shabbat 23b) promises:

One who is careful with lighting will have children who — **הָרָגִיל בְּנֵר הֲוָיִין לֵיהּ בָּנִים תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים** *.are Torah scholars*

Candles bring light into the world, as Torah does — **כִּי נֵר מִצְוָה וְתוֹרָה אוֹר** (Mishlei 6:23). Hence women's custom to **daven for their family** after lighting — an auspicious time.

It is not only a women's mitzvah

The mitzvah is **equally incumbent on men and women**. Women take precedence by tradition (traditionally being at home), but if a man sees his wife is delayed — a minute or two before Shabbat and she is still getting ready — **he should light himself** rather than let Shabbat be desecrated.

Two reasons

1. **Oneg Shabbat** — enjoying Shabbat: food that can be seen is enjoyed more.
2. **Kavod Shabbat** — honour of Shabbat: a lit home, so no one stumbles in the dark.

One candle is sufficient. The old custom is two (corresponding to Zachor and Shamor). If only one is at hand, don't delay looking for a second.

Two separate obligations

There is (1) a **personal** obligation and (2) an obligation that **each home lived in on Shabbat be lit**. Usually one lighting covers both. But:

- **Husband away, wife at home:** her lighting covers the home and his personal duty — **but where he is staying must also be lit**, so he lights there.
- **Wife away, husband at home:** he lights at home; she lights where she is.

Eating out on Friday night, sleeping at home

A common question for young couples eating at their parents:

1. **Best:** light at home at the proper time, ensuring the candles **are still burning when you return**, so you benefit from them. (Lighting and immediately leaving gives no benefit — the bracha would be in vain.) This is not always practical — some are uneasy leaving candles alight, and leaving mid-afternoon is too early to light. *(If you leave after nightfall, having benefited during the first part of Shabbat, that also suffices.)*
2. **Alternatively:** light **where you are eating** — arriving before Shabbat — **preferably in another room** (e.g. the kitchen). For **Sephardim**, once the room is already lit by the hosts, a second lighting there **cannot be made with a bracha**, since it adds nothing.

Forgot to light?

- If it is still **Bein HaShemashot** (twilight — roughly from sunset until nightfall, e.g. 6:00–6:50 pm that week), one may **explicitly ask a non-Jew** to switch on the lights — the principle

being that during twilight one may ask a non-Jew for something needed for Shabbat or for a mitzvah. After nightfall it is too late.

- The **fine** (*knas*): a woman who forgot must add **an extra candle every week** for life. *(Note: large numbers of candles in many homes are a custom of one per child — not penalties!)*
- **Today, since we have electricity**, the poskim rule the fine generally does not apply — the reason for it was a Shabbat spent in darkness. It applies only if she forgot the candles **and** the house was left completely dark.

The bracha — before or after lighting?

The Rabbi polled the room: most light first, then say the bracha.

- **Shulchan Aruch:** the bracha comes **first** — as with every mitzvah (*over la'asiyatan*), e.g. lulav: say the bracha before taking the four species.
- **Rema (Ashkenazim):** light first, **cover the eyes**, say the bracha, then look — because there is an opinion that the bracha constitutes **accepting Shabbat**, after which one could no longer light. Covering the eyes means one has not yet *benefited*, so the bracha is still quasi-before the mitzvah.
- Many **Sephardim** have long done the same — an old custom recorded by the **Chida**, not a recent London borrowing.
- **Practical ruling:** keep your family tradition (follow your mother's custom). With no established custom (e.g. a ba'al teshuva or convert), **say the bracha first, then light**.

Doing melacha after lighting

You light, then realise you forgot to switch off a light:

- **Ashkenazim:** lighting is accepting Shabbat — no more melacha, **unless one stipulates** (*tenai*) at lighting that one does **not** intend to accept Shabbat yet.
- **Sephardim:** strictly, lighting (even with the bracha) is not accepting Shabbat — melacha is permitted until Shabbat.
- **Best for all:** make the stipulation — especially when lighting before driving to a host.

Summary

- **Zachor and Shamor** are equally essential: the beauty of Shabbat and its details — the painting and its brushstrokes.
- Shabbat affirms **Creation**, **Divine Providence** (the Exodus) and our identity as **human beings, not human doings**; it is the **centre** that gives the week meaning (Maharal).
- **Friday work:** in practice almost always permitted until close to Shabbat (simple work, employees, work for Shabbat, financial loss).
- **Friday travel:** permitted as long as you arrive with time to spare and food is expected.
- **Friday meals:** no unaccustomed bread meal all day — except a seudat mitzvah.
- **Candles:** an equal obligation on men and women; two obligations (person and home); options when eating out; the fine largely inapplicable today with electricity; keep your custom on the bracha, otherwise bracha first; for all, stipulate if you intend to continue working after lighting.

Coming Up

Shiur 2 — 23 October: Wine, Beer, Whisky and Spices

- **Kiddush** — its importance, how much to drink, Kiddush on challah
- **The Shabbat meals** — their significance; dieting on Shabbat
- **Havdala** — its various aspects

B'Ezrat Hashem

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